fear of violence, the lack of role models and the fact that many saw their most important responsibility as being towards their own family, rather than the wider country (Lall 2012): '*I would never go into politics, too many double standards*' (Student, Female, Quetta); '*Political parties just work on their interests*' (Student, Male, Kanganpur); '*No one will go into politics. Make your character dirty*' (Focus Group, Government University[23]); '*In present day politics is all about corruption. Anyone who becomes a politician robs and cheats the country that causes misery for the public whereas we should work for the welfare of our country*' (Student, Female, Lahore). Similar sentiments were expressed across the student sample.

The anathema towards politics is a constant theme across the narratives. The findings that politicians are considered 'untrustworthy', only looking out for their own interests, with most of them corrupt and indifferent to the plight of the common man, was not surprising. This was a theme across all institutions from madrassas to government schools, from private to public sector universities. There is a collective abhorrence towards politics, in line with the findings of the Jinnah Institute's work on political activism and the youth (2013). Politicians were perceived to be obsessed with the '*kursi*', the seat of political power which usurps the rights of the people. '*Aaj kal tu buss koi siyaasi kaam keiliyei jamaat nahi buss kursi kei hasul keiliyei aur barei barei ohdei hasil karnei kei liyei hai*'[24] (Student, Female, Lahore).

Others were clear about their perception of political parties, saying they were '*made for the destruction of the country*' (Student, Female, Quetta). The teachers interviewed also did not look fondly at the political structures and political parties that exist: '*Mulk mei afra tafreeh aur muashrati tabaahi ki wajuhaat*'[25] (Academic, Female, Lahore).

Generally, there were responses that attempted to provide a more nuanced definition of political parties, '*[t]o ensure that a country is stably run, and to provide people of equal rights*' (Student, Female, Lahore), but on further probing it was found that the respondents were often referring to the ideal of a political party, not the reality of it in Pakistan. While politics and politicians were regarded with loathing and suspicion, the study further examined young people's understanding of politics, of political activism and political awareness.

Political awareness and activism: A definition

Political awareness, an understanding of the rights and responsibilities of both the citizenry and the state that in turn would lead to political action, for young people was limited to the idea that it simply meant knowledge about political